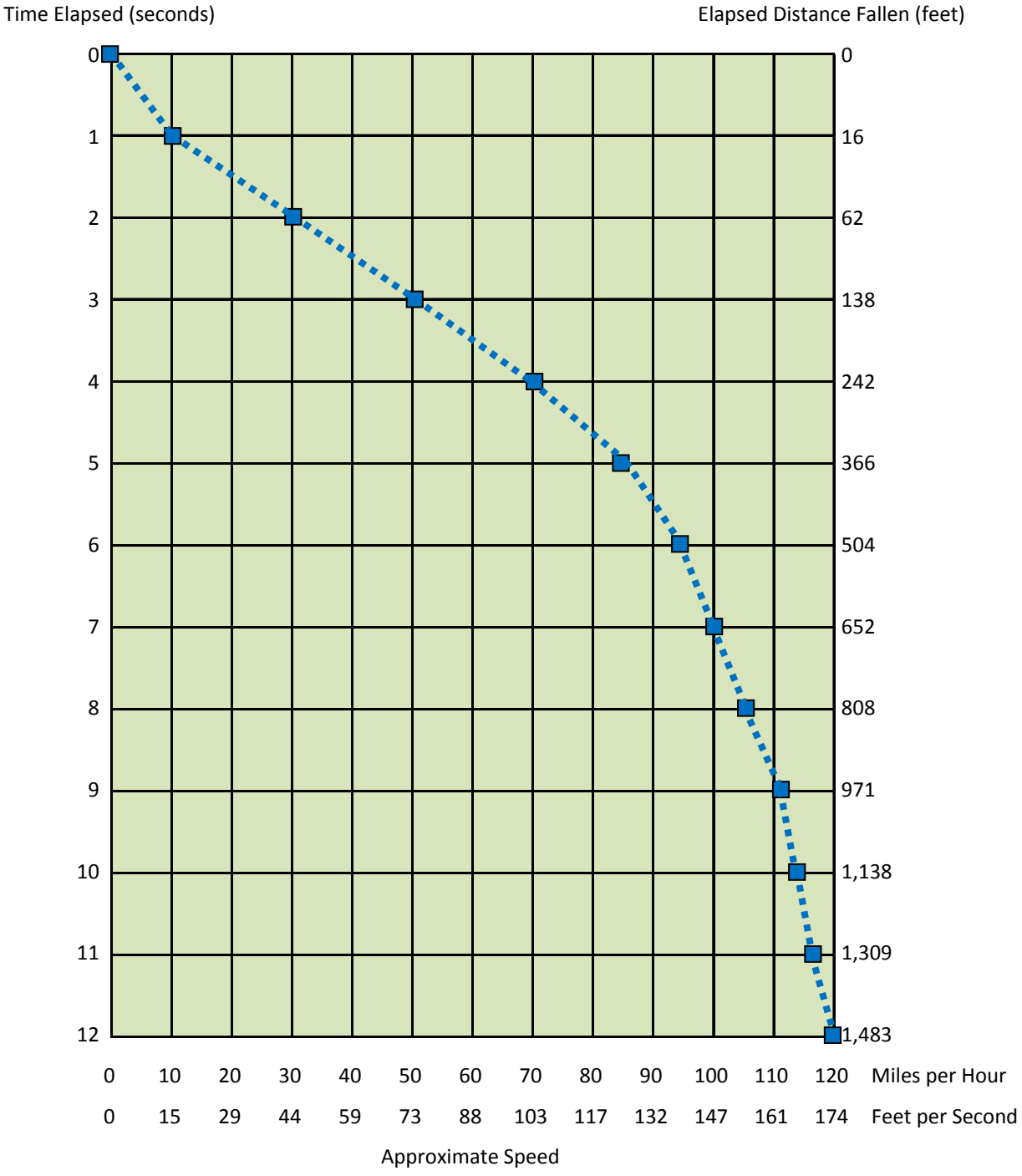
Speed, Distance, and Time of Fall for an Average-Sized Adult in Stable Free Fall Position



Notes:

- Many times we are asked how long it takes a person to fall and how fast they were going. This table is an attempt to answer that question using a data table that skydivers use to estimate their free fall time.
- For example, after six seconds an average-sized person will have fallen 504 feet. Over the last second they will fall about 138 feet, averaging a speed of about 95 miles per hour.
- After about 12 seconds the person falls no faster, so for every additional second the person would fall another 174 feet at a speed of about 118 miles per hour.
- The table on the following page shows the values used in the graphic.

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Values Used in the Graphic

Time elapsed (seconds)	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Approx. speed in feet per second*	0	16	46	76	104	124	138	148	156	163	167	171	174
Approx. speed in miles per hour	0	10	30	50	70	85	95	100	105	110	113	116	118
Distance fallen (feet)	0	16	62	138	242	366	504	652	808	971	1,138	1,309	1,483

* This is an approximation. These values represent the distance fallen over that second. At the end of the second the person will have fallen about 16 feet, but they will have accelerated to a speed faster than 16 feet per second. Yet this value does serve as a good approximation of the speed over the first second. The miles per hour figures are a simple conversion of the feet per second figures.

Green Harbor Publications and the Free Fall Research Page wish to acknowledge Bud Sellick and his book “The Wild, Wonderful World of Parachutes and Parachuting” (Prentice-Hall, 1981) for much of the data upon which the graphic and table are based.

For additional information on the Free Fall Research Page, please visit http://www.greenharbor.com/fffolder/ffresearch.html.

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